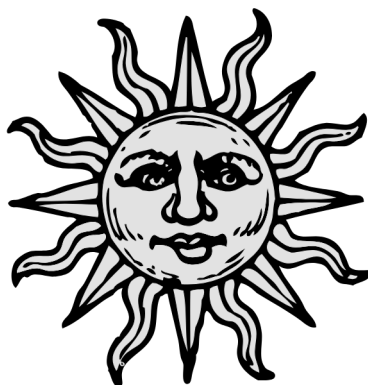




FACTIONS & RUMORS

A GM-TOOLKIT FOR DRAGONBANE ADVENTURES

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LAYOUT:

This game supplement was created using the
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HUMAN MADE

hinokodo.itch.io/human-made

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THE HOMEBREWERY

Homebrewery.Naturalcrit.com



STRUCTURE OF THE WORLD

The basic features of an adventure setting can be categorized into geographic dimensions, measures of time, factions, meta-plot, encounters, and so on. The following pages provide descriptions and guidelines on how to create, structure and run these for a procedural adventure setting that still has that specific Dragonbane feeling to it.

SPACIAL DIMENSIONS

The basic geographic structure of an adventure setting can be divided into regions, areas, adventure sites, and locations – ordered from largest to smallest. Each level is relevant for a different aspect of the game and offers different features and random tables.

MEASURING TIME

In addition to the normal three units of time, this supplement introduces 2 additional units to measure longer durations. A week is about the time required to travel to and from an adventure site and to plan and resolve faction missions.

UNIT OF TIME	DURATION	ENOUGH TIME TO...
Week	5~8 days	Play through an adventure site, resolve a faction mission.
Season	~90 days	Heal severe injuries, resolve a long-term faction mission.

GEOGRAPHY

REGIONS

A region is the largest mechanically relevant place of an adventure. The maps included in official adventures depict regions – with exceptions (see box below).

- ♦ **Meta-Plot:** A region holds an plot or adventure arc that is played out in the various adventure sites.
- ♦ **Factions:** There should be a number of factions active in a region, that can be encountered frequently.
- ♦ **Regional Events:** Some regions have random events tables for events that affect the whole region.

ALTERNATE SCALES

SMALLER THAN A REGION: If it does not make sense to divide an adventure setting into multiple areas – if it takes place in a large city like Arkand or the dwarven mines of the Gates of Power (Path of Glory) – it can simply consist of a single area without defining a full region.

MULTIPLE REGIONS: A larger adventure setting can feature multiple regions. In this case, each region should still have its distinct overarching plot and distinct factions to warrant the separation into regions. It should also be made clear how the regions connect, by what means of transport the party can get from one to the other, and how long it takes them to get there.

AREAS

Map areas are parts of a region, unified by a similar landscape, vegetation and general vibe or feeling.

- ♦ **Journeys:** Areas structure journeys in the region, each area takes about a day to a week to cross.
- ♦ **Random Encounters Table:** Each area has a random encounters table that determines what you can discover during travel.

ADVENTURE SITES

Adventure sites encompass a self-contained part of an adventure, like a village, a dungeon or castle. An adventure site is the place where adventures play out.

- ♦ **Overview Map:** An adventure site provides an overview map with numbered locations for orientation.
- ♦ **Random Events Table:** This table holds wandering monsters, traps or other events and is triggered each stretch the party spends in the adventure site.

LOCATIONS

Locations are the single rooms, halls, courtyards and other spaces that make up the adventure site.

- ♦ **Descriptions:** Each location holds descriptions on which traps, hidden treasure, monsters, or NPCs are present, and exits leading to other locations.
- ♦ **Encounter Die Size:** Locations can have different die sizes to roll on the adventure site's random events table to limit what can happen here.

THE META-PLOT

The meta-plot is the big thing that is currently going on in the region. It is what generates the conflict between the factions. A fight for control of the region – like the search for a powerful artifact, struggle for power, or conflicting ideas on how to deal with a common threat.

FACTION GOALS

The meta-plot determines the goals of a faction in the region. Factions can have larger goals, like re-establishing the empire, that transcend their regional goals. But the goals relevant for play are about what they seek in this region – like searching for the ancient crown.

Factions can have completely asymmetric goals that nonetheless come into conflict with each other. An example would be the druid circle that wants to heal nature and the settlers fleeing from a war trying to tame the land to settle here.

PLOT PROGRESS

A good meta-plot should have a simple way to measure the player character's and faction's progress towards their goals. This can be the number of keys gathered, proportion of strategically important sites conquered, number of villages liberated, or something similar.

EXAMPLE META-PLOTS

HUNT FOR THE KEYS

The most used meta-plot in Dragonbane adventures so far has been factions looking for parts of a key to a powerful artifact. In this meta-plot, the different factions all have the same primary goal: to find the keys and get the artifact first.

A GAME OF THRONES

A more subtle meta-plot is different factions competing for power over the region – ordering assassinations, stealing secrets, and even engaging in small skirmishes. In this scenario, factions either have the goal to gain power or prevent others from gaining it, and tend to use different methods – either subterfuge or overt force.

ALL OUT WAR

The most terrible type of conflict between factions is an all-out war. The goal of factions engaged in war have the goal of destroying each other. A war can also break out between political factions vying for power when court intrigue and proxy-battles are no longer effective.

THE HUB

It is always good to have a regional hub – like Outskirt (in the Core Set Adventures) – a camp, village or town where the player characters can rest safely, buy and sell gear, and hear the latest rumors about adventure sites.

RUMORS

The regional hub is where player characters can hear rumors. That is why a hub has a Rumors Table. Each rumor should point the player characters to an adventure site or to a place in town, where an adventure scenario takes place.

FACTION RUMORS: When factions start missions, people will notice and talk about what they saw or heard. This gossip can then be added to the rumor table. A rumor about a faction mission should not reveal the mission's goal, but should alert the player characters that something is going on in an adventure site.

BACKDROP

Beside the main factions in the adventure, there are many other communities, monsters, bandits, or other beings who dwell in the region and have their own habits and interests.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Each area of a region has its own random encounter table. Such a table contains not only combat encounters with monsters and bandits, but also interesting landmarks or the area, sightings of awe-inspiring beasts, or chance encounters with friendly NPCs.

BACKDROP RUMORS: Some rumors have nothing to do with faction activities, but are about other things going on in the region – like ancient ruins bearing treasure, a local community or tribe who are wary but not necessarily hostile towards the player characters, or a monster that has recently attacked a farm or merchant.

LANDS OF ROULIMAR

The adventure takes place in the Lands of Roulimar, a relatively secluded region on the eastern shore of the continent, to the north of the Eastern Lands.

HISTORY

Roulimar has long been inhabited by nightkin and wolfkin, before Eledain's Dragon Empire expanded here and displaced its former people to the barren fringes of the region. The goblins and nightkin have mostly withdrawn to the mountains and the Blackmoore Bogs. Meanwhile the wolfkin clans have mostly withdrawn to the peninsula of the Icewater Cove.

THE CURRENT SITUATION

A couple of years ago, the blood-seer Romuluk, of the Bloodreaver wolfkin clan, communed with an ancient spirit called "Aistra" during a ritual of reading deer entrails. The ancient demon presented herself as a mighty spirit of the hunt. She commanded Romuluk to gather his reavers and teach them her blood-rage. Ever since, the Aistra's manic reavers have been spreading fear and terror across the region.

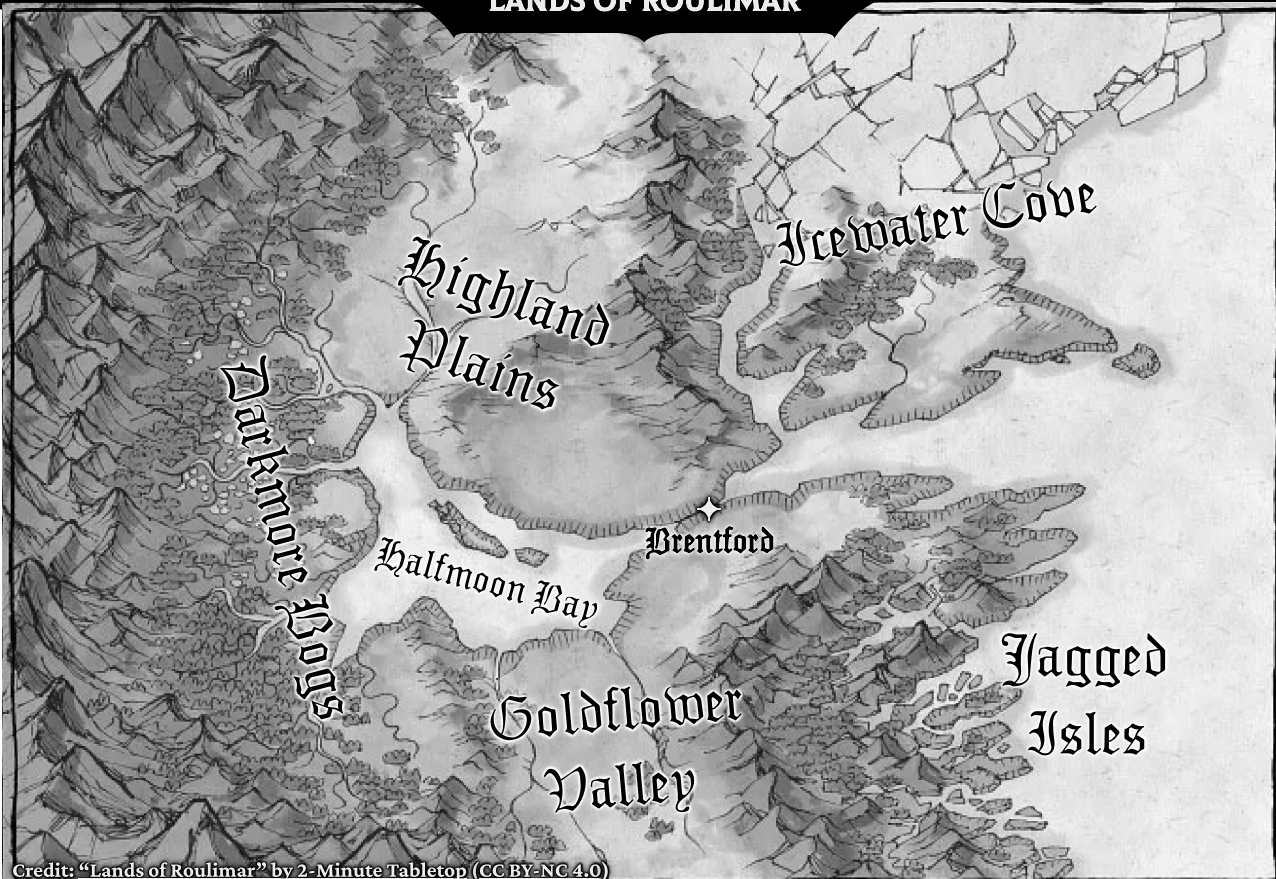
REGIONAL EVENTS

The lands of Roulimar are marked by the growing power of the demon lord Aistra. Whenever the GM finds it fitting, or about once every week, you can roll on the table below for a dark portent that proclaims Aistra's influence.

D6 GRIM PORTENTS

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | DARK STORM. The sky darkens with heavy clouds and icy hail, reddish lightning flashes nearby. |
| 2 | EARTHQUAKE. The ground shakes throughout the region. Cracks and fissures form. |
| 3 | BLOODMOON. During a full night, the moon shines in the color of fresh blood. |
| 4 | VISIONS. Everyone in the region has dreams of a blood-soaked hunt, red in tooth and claw. |
| 5 | CRAZE. A random NPC goes into a crazed rage and attacks everyone nearby. It only lasts a stretch. |
| 6 | LYCANTHROPY. A werewolf has been spotted near or in one of the human or halfling settlements. |

LANDS OF ROULIMAR



Credit: "Lands of Roulimar" by 2-Minute Tabletop (CC BY-NC 4.0)

AREAS

There are about half a dozen larger areas in the Lands of Roulimar that are distinguished by their landscape, ecology or factional presence. Each of them has its own table of random encounters and hold many adventure locations. Here are only a few of them.

GOLDFLOWER VALLEY

A fertile valley dominated by two large rivers, Goldflower Valley is the most populated area in the region. Many humans and halflings have built farms and villages here.

DARKMORE BOGS

Thick bogs and swamps stretch along the western shoreline of Halfmoon Bay. Here, goblins and other outcasts hide in their camps and lairs for unwitting travelers.

HIGHLAND PLAINS

The wind-swept plains to the north of Halfmoon Bay are less welcoming than the valleys to the south.

ICEWATER COVE

The frozen shoreline in the north of Roulimar is the most inhospitable place in the region. Most remaining wolfkin tribes call this peninsula their home.

JAGGED ISLES

The small islands that make up the southern coast are a major hazard to ships and boats in the region.

BRENTFORD

The central hub in the Lands of Roulimar is the town of Brentford, strategically set on the narrow straight separating Halfmoon Bay from the eastern Ocean. While it is not the largest city, Brentford is an important trade port for the region.

Here, an adventure group can hear the current news and rumors about problems and treasures in the region.

EXAMPLE RUMORS

D4 RUMOR

- 1 **HOWLING FORT.** *"On the southern shore of Icewater Cove stands an old abandoned fort of the old empire. You can hear howling from within every night."*
- 2 **MERMAID'S TROVE.** *"Over a decade ago, a pirate ship called the Mermaid's Trove sunk somewhere along the jagged Isles. They say it holds many riches."*
- 3 **TIMMERDALE.** *"A wealthy merchant was brutally murdered down in Timmerdale. Nobody trusts each other there anymore. But some say a monster did it."*
- 4 **IRON HALLS.** *"The dwarven mine in the north-west was abandoned long ago. The dwarfs found many riches but also unleashed a shadow from the deep."*

EXAMPLE RANDOM ENCOUNTERS IN THE DARKMORE BOGS

D12 EVENT

- 1-6 **NOTHING HAPPENS.** The treetops lightly rustle in the wind, you trudge over muddy ground.
- 7 **LEECHES.** A flooded section of the path is riddled with leeches. Anyone wading through the water must roll BUSHCRAFT or take D3 damage and suffer a condition of their choice. Armor has no effect.
- 8 **GOBLIN BANDITS.** A gang of goblins jumps out from the bushes, bows and swords drawn and aimed. "Give us your treasures!" the head goblin yells, "Or we loot it from your dead bodies!" The goblins outnumber the PCs by one and have the stats of typical goblin scout (Rulebook p.90). They flee if half of them are defeated.
- 9 **HUNTING TRAP.** An old bear trap is hidden under a bunch of leaves. All player characters must make an AWARENESS roll in walking order. The first to fail their roll triggers the trap and suffers D6 piercing damage.
- 10 **BOG HORSE.** A greenish-gray horse stands on a small dry patch in the middle of a stagnant pond. It whinnies wildly – seemingly trapped and in distress. The horse is in fact a brook horse (Bestiary p.72) trying to trap the PCs in the bog and feast on them. An AWARENESS roll reveals a previous victim just below the pond's surface.
- 11 **ANCIENT PAVILLION.** The remains of an elven pavillion stands half broken and skewed out of the swamp. It was made of stone and intricately decorated with floral patterns. Now it is overgrown with vines and moss. Player characters who examine the structure with a SPOT HIDDEN roll can find one treasure card.
- 12 **GIANT SPIDER.** A hungry giant spider (Rulebook p.89) has spun its web across the path. All player characters must make an AWARENESS roll – those who fail are trapped in the spider's web (monster attack #5) and the spider attacks next round. The trapped characters must roll STR with a bane to break free.

EXAMPLE – LANDS OF ROULIMAR

FACTIONS

“When you play the game of thrones, you win or you die. There is no middle ground.”

— GEORGE R.R. MARTIN, A GAME OF THRONES

Factions are groups of NPCs who have interests that can align with or come into conflict with those of the player characters. In a typical Dragonbane adventure, you should have at least three factions major with conflicting goals and methods. Their struggle for control and victory generates a dynamic background to your ongoing adventure setting.

FACTION REPUTATION

You can use the reputation rules to track the PCs standing with each of the factions. Directly aiding or interfering with a faction mission counts as an extraordinary deed.

FACTION FEATURES

Factions have **GOALS** they want to achieve, for which they deploy **UNITS** and **ASSETS** in a settlement or to one of the major adventure sites in the region.

GOALS: A faction has one or two specific overall goals in the setting that informs all their activities in the region.

MISSIONS: A faction undertakes missions to enhance their power or progress towards their goals. Typical missions include: recruiting new agents and underlings; searching new assets in adventure sites; increasing their power in a settlement; or attacking a rival faction.

UNITS: The most visible part of a faction are the units they send on missions. There are two types of units: **AGENTS**, like knights or spies, work alone; **GROUPS** include about four to six low-raknig faction members.

ASSETS: Factions own real estate, wealth, tamed monsters or powerful magic items to further their goals. Assets can't do anything on their own but must be used by a faction unit on a mission.

FACTION MISSIONS

SETTING UP MISSIONS

Factions undertake missions to further their goals. Set up new missions and resolve ongoing missions between sessions so that the world changes once the PCs return to a settlement from an adventure site.

To set up a mission, the faction must have a free **UNIT** to assign to it. Missions aim to further a faction's goals, like acquiring assets, attacking an enemy, recruiting more units, or opposing a rival faction's mission.

RUMORS TABLE: Unless a faction deploys a secret agent, a faction mission adds an entry to the rumors table or card deck available to the players – something like “The brotherhood is searching for an ancient temple in the Thornwood” or “The thieves guild is recruiting again”.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS: If a faction sends their units to an adventure site, they can be encountered during travel in the area, if they keep guard posts or patrols in the surrounding area, or when they are still searching for a well-hidden adventure site. Decide whether they are generally hostile, neutral or friendly towards the PCs.

ADVENTURE STIES: If a faction mission sends a unit to an adventure site, it takes a certain amount of time to com-

plete. A simple mission only takes up to a week; More complex missions can take several weeks, during which time the units will be present at the site and can be helped or hindered by the PCs or another faction's units.

RESOLVING MISSIONS

Before setting up new missions between sessions, check whether any ongoing missions are about to end. If player characters were involved in an ongoing mission, whether it succeeds or fails is resolved during play. The faction gains or loses **UNIT** or **ASSET** accordingly.

If the PCs are not involved in a mission, roll on the highest relevant skill rating among all involved **UNITS**:

- ♦ If the roll succeeds, the mission is successful. Depending on the pursued **GOAL**, the faction also gains a new **UNIT** or **ASSET**.
- ♦ If the roll fails, the mission fails or had to be aborted.
- ♦ If a rival faction opposes the mission, resolve both sides with an open opposed roll, only the winning side succeeds in their mission.
- ♦ On a dragon, the winning faction gains an extra reward, but on a demon, one of the **UNITS** or **ASSETS** in play is lost or killed during the mission.

NEGOTIATIONS

When the player characters engage in formal talks with a representative of a faction – like an audience with a faction leader, or parlay with an opposed faction – use the following procedure to structure a negotiation scene.

Negotiations basically work like death rolls (Rulebook p.50). You must make a certain number of successful rolls before you make a number of failed rolls.

STARTING TALKS

To start formal talks, one player character must introduce the group and state their intentions clearly. You can roll on **PERSUASION** to communicate your open and honest desire to talk, **BLUFFING** to trick the other side into talking, or **PERFORMANCE** to make formal introductions in accordance with local custom or dazzle the audience.

- ♦ If the roll fails, they start with their normal patience (see the table on the right).
- ♦ If the roll succeeds, you gain +1 patience for the talks, or +2 if you roll a dragon.

RELUCTANCE

The other party's reluctance to grant your request determines how many successes you need to convince them.

- ♦ A normal request requires 2 successes.
- ♦ A bold request requires 3–4 successes.
- ♦ An outrageous request requires 5+ successes.

PATIENCE

The other party comes into a negotiation with a certain degree of **PATIENCE**, set by their general attitude towards you and how well you initiated the talks.

ATTITUDE	BEHAVIOUR	PATIENCE
Hostile	Will attack and hunt you	0
Evasive	Mistrusted but not hostile	1
Indifferent	No benefits, no problems	2
Friendly	Trusted but not blindly	3
Allies	Will assist you in a fight	4

NPC MOTIVATION

Dragonbane NPCs have traits and motivation (Rulebook p.106) that inform their goals. A player character with the **INSIGHT** heroic ability can use **AWARENESS** to find out an NPC motivation without using up an turn in the negotiation. But you can only attempt this once.

If the player characters figure out an NPC's motivation, they can use them in their arguments, but each trait or motivation can only be used once per negotiation.

- ♦ If you use an NPC's motivation in your argument, you roll with a boon.
- ♦ If an argument goes against an NPC's motivation, it becomes an opposed roll against their **WIL**.

SCORING SUCCESSSES

During negotiation, every player character can try to make their case and roll on a skill. Each roll has to use a different skill or be made by a different player character.

- ♦ **Success:** Gain 1 **SUCCESS** or learn about a **TRAIT** or **MOTIVATION** of the other party.
- ♦ **Dragon:** In addition, choose to gain +1 **SUCCESS**, learn a **TRAIT** or **MOTIVATION**, or restore 1 **PATIENCE**.
- ♦ **Failure:** Mark off 1 **PATIENCE** (2 if you roll a demon).

If you fail **BLUFFING** and are caught in a lie, the other party becomes **DISGRUNTLED** and the player characters get a bane for the rest of the negotiation.

NEGOTIATION OUTCOMES

If you feel that you have rolled enough successes, or if the other party's patience reaches zero, tally up the number of successes you have scored and determine the outcome as described below.

- ♦ **Surpassed:** If you score more successes than required, the other party agrees to your proposal and grants you an additional boon or request.
- ♦ **Matched:** If you score exactly as many successes as needed, the other party agrees to your proposal.
- ♦ **Partial Success:** If you score some successes, but less than required, the other party does not agree to your proposal, but will offer you a worse deal or an enemy faction will allow you to retreat unharmed.
- ♦ **No Successes:** If you fail to score any successes, the other faction does not agree with your proposal and offers you nothing – you might want to leave, now!.

EXAMPLE NEGOTIATION

SUCCESSSES: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ Reluctance 4

FAILURES: ○ ○ Patience 2

EXAMPLE FACTIONS

RULE OF THREE

You can use the “the good, the bad, and the ugly” rule of thumb to create the major three factions in your adventure setting:

THE GOOD: A self-righteous faction, like a knights’ order or religious institution that seeks to spread law and order. However, their “goodness” can be questionable.

THE BAD: A chaotic faction that uses stealth and subterfuge to achieve its selfish and power-hungry ambitions. They can be allied to the PCs but will likely betray them.

THE UGLY: This faction can be any wild or untamable horde, like a nightkin clan, barbarian tribe or band of pirates. To ally with them, the PCs must first prove themselves.



KNIGHTS ORDER OF THE CLEANSING FIRE

Another offshoot of the Keepers of the Immaculate Flame, these knights see them-

selves as the only true heirs to the ancient dragon knights of emperor Eledain. The order stands for the cleansing of the corrupted with fire and sword, and adhere to strict codes of purity, truth, duty, and order. They too seek to re-establish Eledain’s empire, but hold that the other sects of self-proclaimed dragon knights have fallen off the one true path. They carry a banner of stylized dragon wings gleaming with light.

GOAL: Their primary goal is to oppose the machinations of the demon prince Beliel in the south and hunt his followers and cultists with a fierce determination.

UNITS: The three dragon knights Thorfinn, Mereniel and Herderik (**AGENTS**); Hired adventurers (**GROUP**)

ASSETS: An ancient longsword, warhammer, and morn-ingstar that all glow when demons are nearby

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Recruit squires or hire mercenaries (+**GROUP**)
- ◆ Uncover ancient dragon empire artefacts (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Bring cultists **GROUPS** or **AGENTS** to swift justice



REAVERS OF AISTRA

Aistra is the incarnation of feral rage, blood-lust and the visceral hunt of natural predators. While she hails from a demonic realm of madness and chaos, some of the wolfkin clans of the north view her as an ancient natural force. Her worshippers paint themselves in the blood of their prey and cut a cross of claw marks into their own flesh.

GOAL: Aistra revels in the ecstasy of the primal hunt and seeks to make the region wild and feral again.

UNITS: Wolfkin reavers (**GROUP**); The blood-seer Romuluk (**AGENT**); Night assassin Husk (**AGENT**)

ASSETS: Messenger crows; A ritual to summon a blood demon (**SUMMON CHAMPION**, Bestiary p.136)

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Raid a nearby human farm or village (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Convert from other wolfkin clans (+**GROUP**)
- ◆ Covertly assassinate a rival faction **AGENT**



GRINNING SKULL BANDITS

A cunning goblin chief Gut has united the goblins and hobgoblins of the region, and even a few orcs and ogres under her banner.

Her gang seeks to gain treasure, and follows the creed that you own what you can keep away from others.

GOAL: While the goblins ultimately seek to take back their land from the “daykin” (humans and halflings), they are happy to steal their property, for now.

UNITS: Goblin scouts (**GROUP**); Hobgoblin warriors (**GROUP**); The orcish shaman Karakmûl (**AGENT**); The ogre twins Mog and Mrak (**AGENTS**)

ASSETS: A bandit camp hidden in the Darkmore Bogs; A small pack of riding worgs (enough for a **GROUP**)

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Raise a champion among the ranks (+**AGENT**)
- ◆ Raid a nearby daykin farm or village (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Defeat a daykin **GROUP** or **AGENT** in combat

FACTION SHEET

FACTION
NAME:

UNITS & ASSETS

NAME

TYPE

REPUTATION

D20 ▼ GOOD DEEDS

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D20		▲ BAD DEEDS

MAP AREA SHEET

AREA NAME:

Map areas are places within a region that are unified by a similar landscape, vegetation and general vibe or feeling.

Areas have the following features:

- ◆ Areas structure a group's journey through the region.
- ◆ An area is typically large enough to take cross in a couple of shifts, but can take up to a couple of days.
- ◆ Each area has its own Random Encounters table for what you discover while traveling through it.

ADVENTURE SITES

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Roll on a Random Encounters table about every shift.

◆ Or simply select a suitable encounter instead of rolling.

D12 EVENT

1-6 **NOTHING HAPPENS.**

7

8

9

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12